

Negotiating Work-Life Boundaries in a Collectivist Context: The Case of Chinese Teachers on WeChat

Yihe Wang

ywan1125@ucsc.edu

University of California Santa Cruz
Santa Cruz, California, USA

David Lee

dlee105@ucsc.edu

University of California Santa Cruz
Santa Cruz, California, USA

Kehua Lei

klei4@ucsc.edu

University of California Santa Cruz
Santa Cruz, California, USA

Kathryn E. Ringland

kringlan@ucsc.edu

University of California Santa Cruz
Santa Cruz, California, USA

Abstract

The integration of mobile technology in education raises concerns about teachers' work-life boundaries. Most studies examine boundary issues from a Western, individualistic perspective, prompting the question: How might work-life balance be understood within the context of a collectivist culture? This study examines how Chinese teachers manage boundaries on the all-in-one app WeChat. A survey of 108 teachers shows most view WeChat positively for work, while interviews with 18 teachers reveal that while teachers experience fatigue from blurred boundaries and constant availability, they also view WeChat as indispensable for managing fragmented responsibilities, sustaining relationships, and coordinating collective tasks. Teachers employ workarounds to negotiate expectations of accessibility. These practices highlight what we describe as *expected permeability*, a relationally constructed rhythm of accessibility shaped by obligations and tie-specific norms, while foregrounding *relational agency* as a stronger lens for rethinking both platform design and work-life balance theory beyond individualistic framings.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; **Empirical studies in collaborative and social computing**.

Keywords

Teacher, All-in-One, WeChat, Computer-Mediated Communication, Work-Life Boundary, Boundary Negotiation

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1 Introduction

Mobile technologies have become essential in educational settings at various levels (e.g., [39, 49, 75, 96]). These platforms facilitate communication between teachers and students [48], encourage parental involvement [39], and streamline information sharing among school staff. However, while these platforms enhance out-of-class engagements, they have also raised concerns about new challenges for teachers [49], such as information overload, privacy concerns, and increasingly blurred boundaries between work and personal life [9, 24, 39, 49, 99, 100].

In China, concerns over mobile technologies blurring the boundaries between work and personal life is particularly pronounced [111, 116]. Chinese employees face high work pressures [108] and often sacrifice family life for work [117], making it common to continue using communication tools for work purposes after hours [71]. For K-12 teachers in China, these pressures are further amplified due to factors such as managing large numbers of students [14], the significant emphasis placed on students' performance in crucial entrance examinations [85], and increasing parental expectations stemming from substantial investments in their children's education [22]. Additionally, societal expectations that teachers uphold high moral standards and demonstrate exceptional dedication to their profession often compel them to work beyond official hours [36]. As a result, many teachers frequently engage in work-related communications through platforms such as WeChat and QQ¹ during their personal time [39]. However, the platforms' multifunctionality, particularly its social networking features, blurs the lines between professional and personal interactions, making it even more challenging for teachers to maintain clear boundaries.

Existing research on work-life balance has employed boundary theory and border theory to explore how individuals construct and maintain distinctions between work and non-work domains through the creation of mental and physical boundaries [7, 79]. According to these theories, stress, and conflict arise when these boundaries are breached due to the intrusion of one domain into another [61]. Mobile technologies are often implicated in such spillover effects [32]. Given the widespread use of WeChat in education, we initially hypothesized that WeChat would disrupt teachers'

¹Tencent QQ, also known as QQ, is an instant messaging software service and web portal developed by the Chinese technology company Tencent and launched in 1999.

work-life balance. However, our survey across China suggests otherwise: many educators view after-hours WeChat use as an integral part of their professional duties.

These findings differ from much of the existing Western-centric research, which emphasizes personal autonomy and individual control over balancing work and life [7, 18, 19, 60, 61]. In contrast, China's collectivist culture places a greater emphasis on relational harmony and collective well-being [57]. For example, Chinese healthcare professionals often continue communicating with patients outside of official working hours via platforms like WeChat, reflecting an extended sense of responsibility toward the community [30]. This cultural perspective aligns with Fei's social relations theory, which posits that relationships in Chinese society are fluid and interconnected, lacking clear boundaries between categories such as family, friends, and colleagues [35]. Consequently, professional and personal domains frequently overlap, potentially leading to even more pronounced blurring of work-life boundaries [46]. These cultural and institutional dynamics make Chinese teachers an analytically powerful case for examining boundaries in collectivist settings, as their shifting responsibilities and position at the intersection of multiple stakeholders require constant boundary negotiation.

In this paper, we ask: *How might work-life balance be understood and managed within the context of a collectivist culture, such as that of China?* We approach culture as an interpretive lens [56] rather than a deterministic explanation, for understanding teachers' perceptions, reasoning, and decision-making that guide everyday boundary practices on WeChat. We ask:

- **RQ1.** What role does WeChat play in shaping how Chinese teachers experience the overlap of work and life?
- **RQ2.** How do teachers perceive boundary negotiations as shaping their interpersonal relationships?
- **RQ3.** What boundary-work practices do teachers employ on WeChat?

To explore this, we conducted a mixed-methods study consisting of a survey of 108 teachers across China and in-depth interviews with 18 teachers from varied regions, roles, and school levels. Interestingly, despite concerns that using mobile technology can cause boundary violations in teachers' personal and professional lives [39, 49, 100], most teachers in our survey study viewed WeChat positively as a practical tool for work communication. Many even felt that it helped with work-life balance by improving efficiency. From our interview, we further found that although WeChat introduces pressures of constant availability and blurred personal-professional boundaries, teachers in China often view it as indispensable to their work. They strategically mobilize its features to manage fragmented responsibilities, sustain cooperative relationships, and signal availability in ways that minimize conflict.

This paper makes three key, culturally grounded contributions to HCI and CSCW:

- **Empirical.** An account of how Chinese teachers leverage an all-in-one platform as *constructive work-life infrastructure*, enabling hybrid activities, mediating relational distance, and supporting teacher-driven adaptations that reorganize everyday coordination.

- **Conceptual.** The construct of *expected permeability*, showing that availability is shaped by culturally rooted hierarchies, reciprocity norms, and moral obligations, enacted through relational rhythms such as delayed replies, batching, and lightweight signaling.
- **Design-oriented.** A set of four design tensions that surface a culturally situated design space and outline corresponding implications for how communication systems can better support teachers' boundary negotiation. These tensions reveal how systems might navigate role-specific expectations, tacit relational negotiation, emotional demands, and the value of low-friction simplicity to meaningfully support boundary work in relational and culturally attuned ways.

2 Related Work

2.1 Theoretical Reconsideration of Work-Life Boundaries

2.1.1 Theoretical Frameworks. Work-life boundaries have been widely examined through two complementary frameworks [106]: Boundary Theory [7] and Border Theory [25]. Boundary Theory conceptualizes boundaries (e.g., "work" and "home") as individually constructed and adjusted to organize daily life [7, 79]. Border Theory similarly emphasizes how people seek "balance" [25] by maintaining physical, temporal, and psychological borders [42], which vary in their *permeability* [7], i.e., the extent to which work and nonwork demands cross domains and *flexibility*, i.e., the extent to which the boundary can expand or contract to accommodate the demands of the other domain [7]. Consequently, individuals engage in *boundary work*, the ongoing effort to manage, reinforce, or adjust boundaries as daily pressures shift [62, 79].

Although often framed as a matter of personal preference or self-regulation [9, 24], a growing body of research demonstrates that individuals rarely manage boundaries alone. Classic boundary theory already hints at this relational dimension. As Ashforth et al. [7] note, "*role transitions are shaped by role senders' expectations and the salience of identities*", and they immediately add that "*the individual remains the central agent managing such transitions*." Building on this foundation, subsequent work shows that boundary work is shaped by contextual norms, organizational expectations, and shifting sociotechnical conditions [26, 89, 102]. Extending this view, emerging work demonstrates that boundaries are negotiated within relationships of care, dependency, and trust. For instance, across illness recovery, stigma management, and parent-child collaboration [3, 92, 113]. These studies collectively suggest that individual autonomy is not always the center of boundary management. Rather, boundaries emerge from the continuous negotiation of relational obligations, moral expectations, and social interdependencies that structure everyday practices of care and responsibility.

2.1.2 Mobile technology: work-life disruptions or work-life cooperation? Prior literature shows that mobile technologies can intensify boundary blurring in ways that are *destructive*. Mobile technologies increase *role blurring* [9, 24, 29], leading to frequent *microrole transitions* [7] and potential boundary conflicts [6, 40, 60] in terms of demands and/or identity. Thereby, individuals may experience *boundary violations*, defined as "an individual's perception that a

behavior, event, or episode either breaches or neglects an important aspect of the desired boundary” [61]. These violations often occur when “the strain caused by stressors in one domain triggers stressful situations in another domain” [40]. Such spill-overs are particularly concerning because they exacerbate stress and intensify work-life conflict by emphasizing the tensions and misalignment between different life domains [61, 87].

However, recent work also shows that boundary blurring can also be *constructive*. Ding et al. [30] found that mobile technologies do not simply disrupt established boundaries but create new relational spaces, temporal rhythms, and interaction norms that integrate informal patient-provider communication into everyday routines. This raises a broader question: must work-life boundaries remain stable and clearly defined, or can their permeability open new forms of collaboration? Ding et al. explore this phenomenon through the lens of the *boundary objects* [15, 63, 64, 93] commonly discussed in CSCW and related fields, which originally were to emphasize objects and information that cross boundaries between communities [93]. In this field of boundary studies, an increasing number of scholars are questioning the pursuit of stable boundaries and thereby rethinking the role of mobile technologies. In multidisciplinary design work, Lee [63, 64] show how team members use boundary negotiating artifacts to push, reshape, or reinforce boundaries through ongoing exchange. Likewise, in organizational change contexts, Bødker [15] highlights the fluidity of boundaries and calls for technologies that adapt to evolving work arrangements. Teams using shared software as *boundary objects* further illustrate how distributed groups coordinate roles and enact relational forms of action [64, 70]. Extending this relational view, Edwards introduces *relational agency* [34], which highlighted human agency as achieved through relationships rather than in isolation. As we discuss in Section 5.3, this lens offers a productive direction for examining work-life boundaries. Together, these studies advocate for resilient yet flexible boundaries that support both structure and adaptability [70].

2.2 Cultural Logics Shaping Teachers’ Work-Life Boundaries in China

2.2.1 Internalized moral duty and the teacher’s vocational ethic. Across cultures, meaningful work fosters devotion and identity formation [67, 80]. As for teachers in China, whose values are deeply rooted in Confucian philosophy, there is an inherently paternalistic perspective on their role [81]. They are expected not just to instruct but to embody moral virtue, guiding students by example [81]. Although market reforms and social shifts have weakened teachers’ authority, with parents increasingly viewing them as service providers [21, 109, 110], China still holds teachers in high regard [101]. Seen through the lens of Weber’s notion of *Berufsethik* [105] and the Confucian concept of fulfilling one’s duty [98], teaching remains tied to an internalized sense of moral responsibility that transcends contractual boundaries.

2.2.2 Interpersonal Logics - Hierarchy, Face, and Reciprocity. Boundary negotiation in Chinese educational settings is shaped by enduring cultural logics of hierarchy and collectivism. As a high power distance society [51], China normalizes structured relations in which inequalities are expected and appropriate. In classrooms,

this produces teacher-centered, formally ordered, and deferential interaction patterns [52, 54]. Collectivist values further emphasize group harmony and relational obligation over individual preference [97]. Within this framework, boundaries are not enforced through explicit rules, but through the subtler, culturally encoded expectations of proper conduct within relational roles, particularly those tied to face and reciprocity [37, 55]. Face functions as both a moral asset and a form of social currency, linking one’s dignity, status, and relational balance [37, 55]. In Hwang’s “face-favor-guanxi” model [55], Chinese social interactions as a kind of power game built on exchanging favors and face. These interpersonal logics therefore provide an important lens for understanding how teachers may perceive and manage boundaries in their everyday communication.

2.2.3 Informal moral governance in the absence of institutional policies. Across the Global South, digital labour and communication routinely unfold amid institutional voids [44, 45], where informal norms frequently take on the work of managing work-life boundaries [28, 74]. In China’s educational context, teachers internalized standards of self-discipline [35, 98] (introduced in **Section 2.2.1**) substitute for formal boundary guidance by shaping when, how, and to what extent they believe they ought to remain accessible. In contrast, policies such as Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) [86] in the United States operationalize boundaries by specifying concrete requirements for handling student information and educator communication. Although China has enacted comprehensive personal information laws, including the Law on the Protection of Minors [43] and the Personal Information Protection Law (PIPL) [16], these frameworks remain principle based and offer limited practical guidance for teachers’ communication in schools. The PIPL relies heavily on broad consent requirements and uniform protections, with little attention to the specific needs of educational contexts [41, 115]. Beyond data protection, schools offer little formal guidance on teachers’ professional self-presentation or relational conduct on digital platforms, leaving these boundary-related decisions to informal moral norms.

2.3 Teaching Lives with Mobile Technologies

The integration of mobile technologies has transformed educational practices globally, offering innovative approaches for teachers to communicate, collaborate, and engage with students. Platforms such as instant messaging (IM) and social networking services (SNS), including Facebook [8, 10, 11, 47, 94], WhatsApp [38, 78, 99, 100], and WeChat [39, 75], have played a significant role in reshaping teacher-student and teacher-teacher interactions.

In Western contexts, extensive research highlights how these technologies foster professional communities, improve instructional practices, and enhance teacher-student dynamics. For instance, studies have explored Facebook as a medium for informal professional development, with teachers using it for mentoring, resource sharing, and fostering community support [10, 11]. Furthermore, teacher self-disclosure on platforms like Facebook has been shown to enhance teacher credibility and build closer student-teacher relationships [73]. Beyond Western contexts, the use of mobile technologies in educational settings mostly set its context in HCI4D, addressing infrastructural challenges by fostering teacher

networks, promoting collaboration, and supporting professional development in resource-constrained and remote areas [75, 78, 99].

Although mobile technologies have expanded educational possibilities beyond physical and temporal limitations, many studies have highlighted their negative impacts, particularly the threat they pose to teachers' personal boundaries [47, 94]. However, research specifically addressing teachers' well-being in the context of technology use remains limited. One notable example is Varanasi et al.'s work [100], which examines technostress (i.e., feelings stemming from the inability to adapt to new technologies) in low-income Indian schools and highlights the feelings of invasion of mobile technologies into their personal sphere. However, this study does not delve deeper into understanding the factors such as societal and cultural influences that shape how teachers perceive boundary issues.

2.4 WeChat: The All-in-One App

WeChat² has become the most popular app in China with over 1.35 billion active monthly users as of the end of March 2024 [2] and the "super-sticky" application in Chinese people's daily lives [23] - by 2017, approximately 30% of mobile internet usage time was spent on WeChat [72]. Often described as a "Swiss army knife" [31], WeChat integrates social networking, communication, payments, and service access within a single platform [77] (see **Figure 1**). Compared with other platforms commonly used by teachers, such as Facebook [8, 10, 11, 47, 94] and WhatsApp [38, 78, 99, 100], WeChat [39, 75] stands out for its dense integration of functions (see Table 1).

WeChat also offers a comparatively closed and tightly controlled social environment. Moments³, its semi-private social feed, restricts visibility to mutually accepted contacts and hides interactions from anyone outside this circle [53]. Scholars argue that such a closed and controlled environment on WeChat allows users to build and manage a wide spectrum of relationships, ranging from strong ties to weak and latent ties, thus enabling them to access a more diverse array of resources through a larger network [88, 114].

A growing body of research shows that WeChat is deeply embedded in professional life. Group chats are commonly used for work coordination, often collapsing personal and professional spheres. Recent studies highlight how WeChat can reinforce workplace hierarchies and expectations of constant availability [95], prompting users to develop strategies such as muting groups or maintaining multiple accounts to reclaim control [111].

Reflection. As discussed above, it has become clear that teachers in China are highly likely to face work-life boundary challenges due to *demands conflict* (e.g., after-hours communication on WeChat [39]) and *identity conflicts* (e.g., presenting incompatible personal and professional selves on WeChat Moments). Yet, most existing research on work-life balance typically centers on professions with clearer work-life boundaries (e.g., engineers, industrial

workers [50]). In HCI, boundary negotiation is a common theme, but studies often focus on platforms with limited functionality (e.g., email [17, 18, 20]), or isolated single features of multi-functional platforms (e.g., messaging on WeChat [30, 39, 69]) with less attention given to examining the *all-in-one* platform as an organic whole. Most importantly, most theories on work-life boundaries are rooted in Western-centric perspectives, even in studies that consider work-life boundaries outside individualist settings [100]. These perspectives emphasize personal autonomy and individual control over balancing work and life [7, 18, 19, 60, 61], neglecting potential cultural differences. While emerging work (e.g., [4]) begins to explore these nuances, cultural dimensions remain underexamined in mobile technology research. Our study addresses these gaps by focusing on Chinese teachers, a profession where work-life boundaries are more complex and less defined [90], and by examining how they navigate boundary challenges through the use of a widely adopted *all-in-one* platform like WeChat. By situating our research in a Chinese context, we aim to critically reflect on the Western-centric nature of existing work-life boundary theories and explore culturally specific dynamics. This approach seeks to provide more culturally relevant insights into designing for work-life balance, both within Chinese society and beyond.

3 Method

We conducted a mixed-methods study combining a survey and separate semi-structured interviews to explore how Chinese teachers navigate boundaries on WeChat, the considerations behind their practices, and the challenges encountered.

3.1 Method Overview

To contextualize boundary theories in the lives of Chinese teachers while minimizing presumptions (e.g., using WeChat disrupts teachers' work-life balance), we carefully structured our study using a combination of the sequential explanatory design and the embedded design outlined by Creswell and Clark [27]. That is, we initiated survey data collection first and used in-progress preliminary survey data to iteratively modify interview designs throughout the process. The embedded structure of our methods ensured that the interview questions were grounded in real-world data and supported a balanced interview sample. In the end, the survey data was also used to provide quantitative evidence to strengthen our insights from interview analysis. **Figure 2** illustrates the study sequence. This study was approved by our university's Institutional Review Board.

3.2 Survey: Contextual Grounding and Quantitative Support

3.2.1 Participants. We recruited 108 teachers across China via social media, including WeChat, Weibo, and RedNotes. A combination of convenient and snowball sampling strategies was used. The first author distributed the survey both publicly and within her professional teacher networks, and teachers who completed the survey were encouraged to share it with their colleagues and peers. Participants were eligible if they are currently teaching in a primary, middle, or high school in mainland China, and using WeChat for work-related communication. Kindergarten teachers were excluded because their work focus and responsibilities are

²WeChat or Weixin in Chinese is a Chinese instant messaging, social media, and mobile payment app developed by Tencent, first launched in January 2011 (as cited in [77]).

³WeChat Moments is a social networking feature that allows users to share photos, text, and links with their contacts in a timeline-style feed. It serves as a blend of personal and professional interactions, where users can control who sees their posts, making it a platform for both private and public expressions within the WeChat ecosystem. Details refer to <https://blog.wechat.com/2015/06/12/tech-tip-your-guide-to-wechat-moments/>

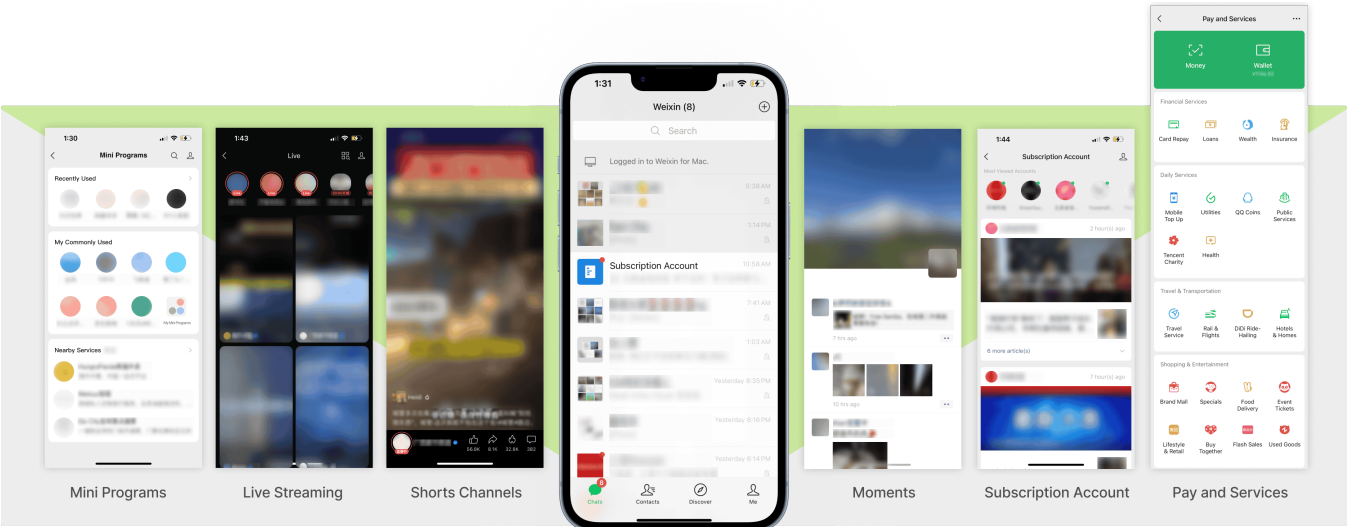


Figure 1: Screenshots of WeChat’s All-in-One Interface, including Mini Programs, Live Streaming, Moments, Subscription Accounts, and integrated payment and service options.

Functionality	WhatsApp	Facebook	WeChat
Extensions			✓ Mini-Programs
Live Streaming		✓	✓
Short Videos		✓	✓
Social Media Services		✓	✓ Moments
Group Chat & DMs	✓	✓ Messenger	✓
Subscriptions/Blogs			✓ Official Accounts
Cashless Payments	✓ WhatsApp Business	✓	✓ WeChat Pay

Table 1: A brief comparison of WhatsApp, Facebook, and WeChat as of August 2025.

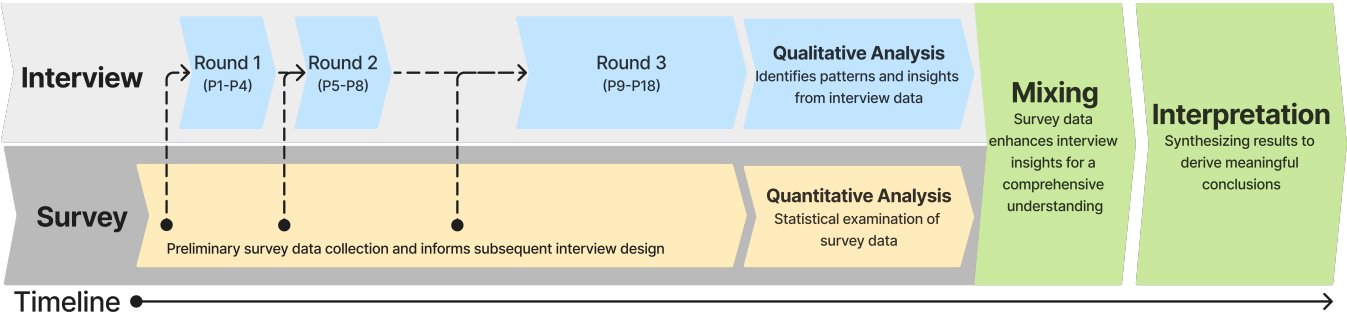


Figure 2: Mixed-methods study design illustrating the integration of survey and interview data.

often more caregiving-oriented. Survey participation was entirely voluntary, and no financial or material compensation was provided. The final sample represented teachers of diverse ages, genders, teaching experiences, grade levels, regions, roles, and subjects. Full demographic details are in **Table 2**. We also asked whether participants served as homeroom teachers, since this role involves constant parent communication and cross-subject coordination,

making it a key factor in understanding differences in boundary permeability and expectations of availability.

3.2.2 Instrument. The survey provides contextual insights into the experiences of teachers using WeChat for work, focusing on their demographics, roles, and school settings. We asked about teachers’ daily WeChat usage, both general and work-related, as well as the frequency and perceptions of interactions with students,

parents, and colleagues through messaging and Moments. We also asked whether institutions have established practices regarding WeChat use. Finally, the survey includes direct questions asking overall, impact on teachers' work pressure and job satisfaction. We have included the survey questions in **Appendix A**. The survey instrument remained unchanged throughout the study process.

Attribute	Range	Sample Size
Age	20-30	54.6% (59)
	31-40	26.9% (29)
	41-50	13% (14)
	51-60	5.5% (6)
Gender	Male	28.7% (31)
	Female	71.3% (77)
Teaching Experience (Year)	0-5	46.3% (50)
	5-10	25.9% (28)
	11-15	10.2% (11)
	16-20	1.9% (2)
	20-40	15.7% (17)
Grade	Elementary School	41.7% (45)
	Middle School	40.7% (44)
	High School	17.6% (19)
Region	Urban	67.6% (73)
	Rural	32.4% (35)
Current Roles	Subject Teacher	71.3 (77)
	Homeroom Teacher	41.7% (45)
	School Leadership	21.3% (23)

Table 2: Demographic information of our survey participants. It is noted that some teachers hold multiple roles within the school.

3.3.2 Survey Data Analysis. Survey data were initially analyzed using descriptive methods to identify easily observable distributions, which helped inform participant recruitment and refine interview questions. Following the completion of interviews, we conducted inferential statistical analysis in SPSS, including frequency distributions and chi-square tests, to explore relationships between demographic factors and teachers' satisfaction and work-life balance when using WeChat for work.

3.3 Semi-Structured Interviews: In-Depth Exploration of Boundary Practices

3.3.1 Participants. We recruited 18 participants across China via social media posts for our interviews, with one interviewee coming from the first author's personal network. Our participants included teachers from urban and rural schools across various regions in China to capture potential differences in practices. Participants were required to currently use WeChat for work communication. Eighteen teachers (12 female, 6 male) participated, with teaching experience ranging from 6 months to 30 years. Each taught 1-4 classes (28-77 students per class; avg. 46). Participants received a 150 RMB (approximately 25 USD) Tmall Gift Card as compensation. Full demographic information is presented in **Table 3**.

3.3.2 Interview Design. Our interview design was guided by boundary theories, occupational meaningfulness, and workplace relational norms. We focused on two dimensions: individual vs. collective boundary work and identity vs. demand. At the individual level, we asked how teachers manage WeChat-based work interactions, addressing tensions of demand (e.g., constant availability) and identity (e.g., balancing professional and personal presence). At the collective level, we examined how institutional norms, policies, and peer expectations shape boundaries, probing demand pressures (e.g., responsiveness) and identity ideals (e.g., being a "good teacher"). Finally, we asked about their personal understanding of their occupation and their perception of personal boundaries. During iterating the interview questions, the in-progress survey results showing that most teachers perceived WeChat as supporting work-life balance prompted targeted follow-up questions such as "After working hours or on weekends, do you still use WeChat often? What do you mainly use it for?", "Do you handle work matters through WeChat after hours? If yes, how do you feel about that? Do you see it as overtime?", and "Overall, how would you describe the role of WeChat in your life?". These questions invited teachers to explain why constant connectivity felt compatible with balance, while later items on expectations and perceived advantages deepened this exploration. Survey demographics also guided interview recruitment to ensure diversity across school stages, regions, and years of experience.

The first author, a native Mandarin speaker, conducted all semi-structured interviews in Mandarin via Zoom. To ensure anonymity and comfort, cameras were off. Questions were discussed and iterated by the first two authors after each round of interviews, based on feedback and initial findings. We conducted interviews in three rounds (see **Appendix B** for details on question revisions):

- **First Round (Early March 2024):** The first author recruited 4 participants (P1-P4) to pilot test the designed interview questions.
- **Second Round (Late March 2024):** The first author conducted another four interviews (P5-P8) with more conclusion questions like "What kind of space does Moments represent for you?" and "What teaching means to you as a profession?".
- **Third Round (August 2024):** In this round of interviews, we not only refined our questions to focus more on the impact of *all-in-one* but also adjusted the diversity of our sample. We aimed to include more experienced teachers to gain insights from long-term WeChat users. Additionally, based on survey data showing that 70.37% of teachers do not separate their WeChat accounts for personal and professional use, we recruited an additional eight participants (P9-P18) who either use a single WeChat account or have more extensive teaching experience.

3.3.3 Interview Data Analysis. All interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim in Chinese. Following Miles et al.'s iterative qualitative procedures [76] and Williams and Moser's thematic exploration framework [107], we deliberately began inductively to avoid prematurely imposing Western boundary constructs, and only later integrated boundary theories as sensitizing concepts. This design allowed empirical patterns grounded in the Chinese cultural context to surface before theoretical framing was applied:

No.	Gender	Teaching Experience (Year)	Teaching Subject	If homeroom teacher	Region	Grade	Using Separated Account
P1	Male	3	Math and Physics	Y	Urban	Elementary School	Y
P2	Female	4	Chinese	N	Rural	High School	N
P3	Female	3	Chinese	N	Urban	Elementary School	Y
P4	Male	5	Chinese	Y	Urban	Elementary School	Y
P5	Male	6	Math	N	Urban	Elementary School	Y
P6	Female	4	Math	N	Urban	Elementary School	Y
P7	Female	1	English	N	Urban	Elementary School	N
P8	Female	6	Music	Y	Rural	Middle School	Y
P9	Female	4	Chinese	Y	Rural	Elementary School	N
P10	Male	4	PE	Y	Rural	Middle School	Y
P11	Female	6	English	Y	Rural	High School	N
P12	Male	7	English	N	Urban	Middle School	N
P13	Male	0.5	Math	Y	Urban	Elementary School	N
P14	Female	12	English	Y	Rural	High School	N
P15	Female	10	History	N	Urban	Middle School	Y
P16	Female	6	English	Y	Rural	High School	N
P17	Female	30	Chinese	N	Urban	Middle School	N
P18	Female	6	Society	N	Urban	Middle School	N

Table 3: Demographic information of our interview participants.

• Inductive Coding and Category Development.

- **Initial Coding Phase.** The first two authors began with *open coding* [107] on four transcripts (P1 - P4), generating 414 initial codes. Many captured teachers' micro-decisions about communication, such as: "messages from leaders must be answered immediately", "close parents can add my personal account", "more distance means more formality", "parents treat teachers as emotional outlets", "teachers are not nannies", "afraid of being reported via screenshots", and "the audience shapes what teacher post in Moments". Through *axial coding* [107], these codes were clustered into relationally grounded categories: "relational closeness shapes access" (e.g., tone, reply speed, account separation), "hierarchy overrides personal boundaries" (e.g., immediate responsiveness to leaders), and "relational risk shapes information disclosure" (e.g., privacy concerns, fear of screenshots). Across these categories, we observed that teachers consistently calibrated boundaries through relational judgment, evaluating closeness, hierarchy, and role expectations.
- **Thematic Refinement and Validation.** Using the preliminary codebook, the first author refined themes through iterative discussions with the last author, focusing on culturally grounded patterns. For instance, codes like "reply instantly to leaders" were grouped under hierarchical boundary pressures, while "close parents can add my personal account" reflected face-sensitive reciprocity in managing relational obligations. These refinements led to the key categories detailed in Section 2.2.

- **Deductive Re-analysis and Theme Development.** After stabilizing inductive categories, we conducted a targeted deductive re-analysis using a sensitizing codebook derived

from boundary theory (permeability, segmentation, violations) [7] and CSCW work on *boundary object* [5, 64]. We applied these constructs to the four inductive relational categories through a matrix-style comparison, re-coding exemplar excerpts to examine where existing theory aligned well and where it provided only partial explanatory power. This process showed that while concepts like *permeability* helped explain practices such as teachers' quick replies to administrators, other patterns, such as delaying responses to signal respectful distance, or adjusting Moments visibility to manage perceived fairness, were less well captured by existing frameworks. Recognizing these recurring gaps across categories allowed us to articulate *expected permeability* in Section 5.2, not as a challenge to prior theory, but as an extension that better captures relationally grounded boundary dynamics in this context.

To minimize cultural bias, the analysis incorporated direct quotes and interpretation checks by the third and fourth authors, who have expertise in online communities but different cultural backgrounds.

4 Findings

4.1 RQ1. WeChat as an Infrastructural Site for Teachers' Work-Life Cooperation

As Yu [111] notes and P13 echoed, WeChat has become infrastructure, expanding across systems, user groups, and functions, a "network of networks" mediating everyday coordination. This infrastructuralization [83, 118] turns WeChat into a site where teachers sustain cooperation across institutions, colleagues, parents, and students (illustrated in Table 4), who hold divergent expectations and routines, therefore functions as a *boundary object* in practice.

4.1.1 Relational expansion through ubiquity. WeChat emerged as the de facto channel for school communication due to its widespread

Temporal Frame	Relational Context	Example Tasks
In-Hours	Administrators/Colleagues	Announcements, lesson-plan sharing, schedule coordination
	Parents	Routine notices, logistics communication, homework instructions
After-Hours	Parents	Scores clarification, behavior follow-ups, urgent event updates
	Students	Feedback, encouragement, exam preparation messages
Hidden/Peripheral	Peers	Moderating class groups, compiling digital records, maintaining mini-programs
	Administrators/Colleagues	Preparing reports, uploading records, documenting student progress for institutional compliance
	Personal/Broad Contacts	Curating visibility on Moments, restricting audiences, maintaining professional image online

Table 4: Teachers’ WeChat tasks across time and relational contexts.

social adoption [68]. Our teachers adopted WeChat for work primarily through institutional practices and social defaults (“everyone was using WeChat” (P7), even when alternatives (e.g., DingTalk⁴) existed. WeChat’s ubiquity ensures reach across diverse stakeholders, including less tech-comfortable staff (“dormitory auntie”, P10) and rural parents. Moreover, Mini-programs⁵ such as *Class House-keeper*⁶ (see **Figure 3**) mentioned by P14, let teachers share scores privately and automate rank/report generation. Group features like *group relay*⁷ which allow sequential input in chats “efficiently gather responses” (P10), streamlining the coordination of relationally entangled school tasks such as organizing attendance, collecting forms, or escalating confirmations. These affordances underscore teachers’ need for a centralized hub to coordinate relationally entangled tasks across students, parents, and the class collective, where, for example, a “grade” is not a standalone number but a shared, ongoing process. Although teachers described WeChat as “for close personal connections” (P18) and a “compressed personal network” (P12), the accumulation of work contacts gradually turned WeChat into a site where both personal and professional interactions unfold side by side. This shared visibility softens workplace hierarchies like “snooping or sharing in the other person’s life”, as P2 put it; and, for some, blurs colleagues into friends: “We’re not just colleagues anymore; we’re friends” (P8).

4.1.2 Merging personal and professional tasks through multifunctionality. WeChat’s multifunctionality collapses teachers’ personal, professional, and social activities into a single stream. Teachers described how personal browsing often turns into professional insight: checking students’ or parents’ Moments is treated as part of

pastoral care (“this is a window for me to understand them”, P8; “I can see family situations and better understand a student”, P5). The same feed also builds collegial intimacy, as teachers follow coworkers’ travels or daily posts and use them to spark casual conversation (P5). Another example, P15 described scrolling through videos for personal interest and coming across *Black Myth: Wukong*⁸, a historically themed game tied to a viral release.

“The game did on-location shooting at 27 historical sites in Shanxi⁹, and because it was a hot topic that aligned with my my course content, I reposted it to Moments.” (P15)

P15 immediately reframed it as a teaching opportunity and captioned the post, “review what we learned”, using the platform as an engaging extension of the classroom.

4.1.3 Temporal spillover and soft continuity. Our survey indicates that more than half of the teachers use WeChat for over two hours daily, and nearly three-quarters exceed three hours. This corresponds to half of the daily internet usage in china, which averaged about 6 hours and 31 minutes for Chinese users in 2024 [1] when the study was conducted. Despite boundary concerns, 67.30% view WeChat as a practical work tool, and 68.22% even believe it can improve work-life balance. Interviews explain this “paradox”: when evaluating whether a tool hinders or supports the balance, most teachers claim that the teaching profession has a “special nature” (P15).

All participants described communication as a crucial part of their job, representing a “continuation” (P5) of their teaching duties. They often need to handle small tasks outside of regular school hours, such as “checking for any last-minute tasks after getting up in the morning” (P15), and “preparing lessons for the next day after work” (P13). As P4 noted, “Our work is continuous, involving both daytime teaching and evening interactions. (P4)” This continuous

⁴DingTalk is a comprehensive communication and collaboration platform developed by Alibaba, primarily used in workplaces and educational institutions across China. It offers features like messaging, video conferencing, task management, and attendance tracking.

⁵WeChat Mini Programs are lightweight, app-like features embedded within WeChat that allow users to perform a wide range of tasks without needing to download separate apps.

⁶<https://banjixiaoguanjia.com/>

⁷WeChat’s Group Relay feature allows users to start a message thread in group chats where others can sequentially add their input, commonly used for organizing tasks, attendance, or lists.

⁸*Black Myth: Wukong* is a 2024 action role-playing game that reimagines the classic Chinese novel *Journey to the West* through cinematic world-building grounded in Chinese mythology and historical scenery.

⁹Shanxi is a plateau province in North China, known for having the largest concentration of historic buildings among all Chinese provinces, many of which are historical and cultural landmarks.

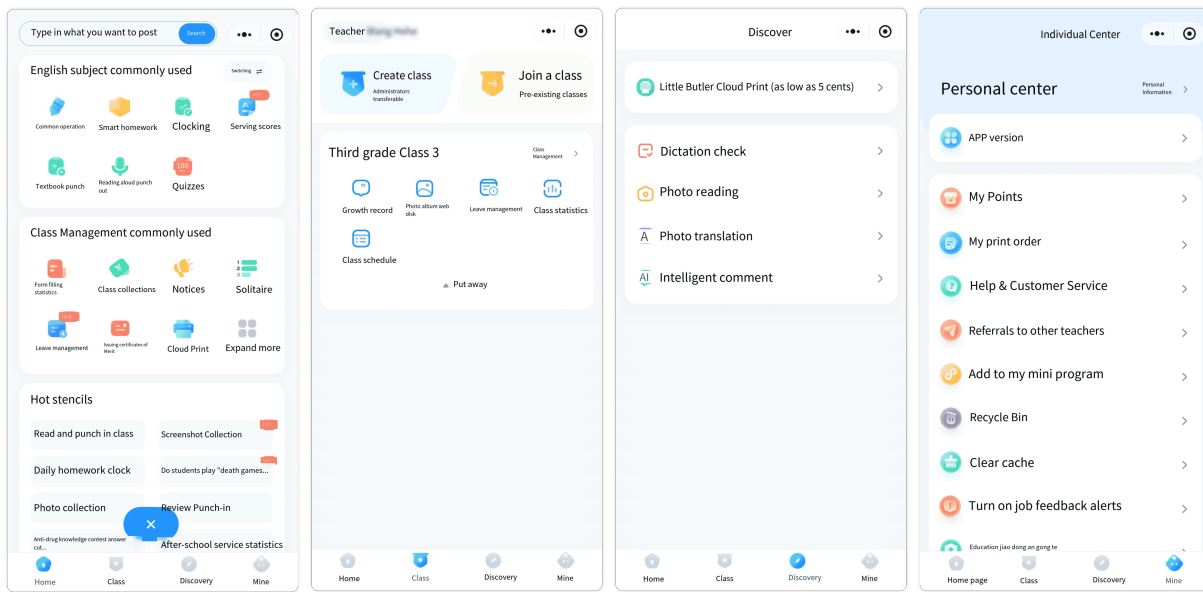


Figure 3: Screenshots of a Mini Program, Class Housekeeper, that teachers use for class management.

communication is often driven by teachers' intrinsic motivation for the profession (see **Section 2.2**). Messages “*lay groundwork*” (P8) for smooth operations and are timed to parents' availability (“*evenings after their work hours*” (P18)). Brief replies were often “*not considered overtime*” (P7). Teachers focus less on *whether* after-hours work should occur and more on *how* to enact it in ways that preserve relationships while signaling reasonable limits.

4.2 RQ2. Boundary Negotiation and Perceptions of its Relational Impact

Originally situated in the private sphere, WeChat has become a core medium through which teachers, parents, and students coordinate school-related communication. This technological shift has made boundaries between work and life more fluid and negotiable. However, teachers' experiences reveal that boundary negotiation on WeChat is not simply about managing time or communication load, it is deeply relational. In practice, teachers find “work” difficult to delimit when students' difficulties are entangled with family contexts (as “*these matters are closely related, because many of the children's issues are tied to their family education*”, P9); and teachers' sense of care, “*we are human*” (P11), draws them into additional affective labor beyond contracted hours. These negotiations are relational acts of positioning shaped by who the role sender is and what expectations teachers perceive from them, enabling teachers to signal their internalized cultural-relational logics (summarized in **Table 5**).

4.2.1 Negotiating responsiveness as moral duty and relational face work. WeChat streamlines access to stakeholders (**Section 4.1.1**), but this convenience, coupled with high communication demand (**Section 4.1.3**), leads to a norm of perpetual availability. P15 captured the embodied strain of “*countless unread*” and hypervigilance

to notification cues. Teachers reported social interruptions, difficulty “*switching off*” (P1). P8 further explained, “*As soon as I saw the messages, I couldn't help starting to deal with them.*” Indeed, after receiving work messages, teachers often feel obligated to respond immediately. According to our survey results, most teachers believe their colleagues, parents, and students expect prompt responses, regardless of the time (see **Figure 4(b)**). Teachers interpret this expectation as a reflection of moral and professional identity. As P3 put it, “*education itself is filled with passion and a spirit of dedication*”. Timely replies, in this view, perform care, conscientiousness, and commitment to teaching as a moral calling. Responsiveness also carries relational weight. It serves as a form of face work [37, 55], signaling respect, reliability, and social tact to parents, students, and administrators.

With 61 out of 108 teachers reporting minimal or no institutional guidance, these moral and relational expectations function as an informal system of accountability. As P2 noted, “*society as a whole lacks a concept of teachers' work boundaries*”. Where policies exist (e.g., P18, P6), they often address superficial matters like “*using foul language*” (P5) or drafting “*more appropriate responses*” (P16), leaving deeper emotional and relational tensions, such as “*parents' own relational issues with their child*” (P5) or “*parental anxiety*” (P8), to the teacher's discretion. Faced with these tasks beyond their educational role, teachers often feel they cannot simply disengage. As P8 put it, “*ignoring messages entirely doesn't feel right either*” (P8). In navigating these blurred boundaries, teachers do not describe “balance” as stepping back, but as learning to stay accessible without compromising moral duty or relational harmony.

4.2.2 Negotiating identity through reputation, virtue, and platform affordances. For most teachers, boundary negotiation on WeChat centers on carefully controlling their self-presentation. They worry

Role Sender	Teacher Perceived Expectations	Cultural-Relational Logics	Representative Quote
Administrators	Immediate response to group messages, fast action on directives	Hierarchy; institutional authority; obligation to show diligence/virtue	<i>“Leaders don’t like seeing you out often, as it may seem like you’re not dedicated to your work.” (P8)</i>
Colleagues	Timely replies in group coordination, material sharing, task alignment	Reciprocity; peer harmony	<i>“When you add someone on WeChat, you can see their Moments, which lets you peek into their life or share in it. It feels like it brings you closer to your colleagues.” (P2)</i>
Parents	Rapid feedback on student performance or issues, after-hours communication	Moral duty; reciprocity; parental anxiety; face management	<i>“We usually respond to anxious parents because ignoring them could strain our relationship. They might think the teacher doesn’t care about their child.” (P8)</i>
Students	Mixed expectations: some share memes with teachers, others prefer privacy and keep teachers out of their digital space	Moral duty/virtue; hierarchical care; respecting students’ desired distance	<i>“Students don’t view teachers as part of their chosen circle of friends, which is why they may feel uncomfortable when we engage with their posts.” (P8)</i>

Table 5: Role Senders and Teacher Perceived Boundary Expectations

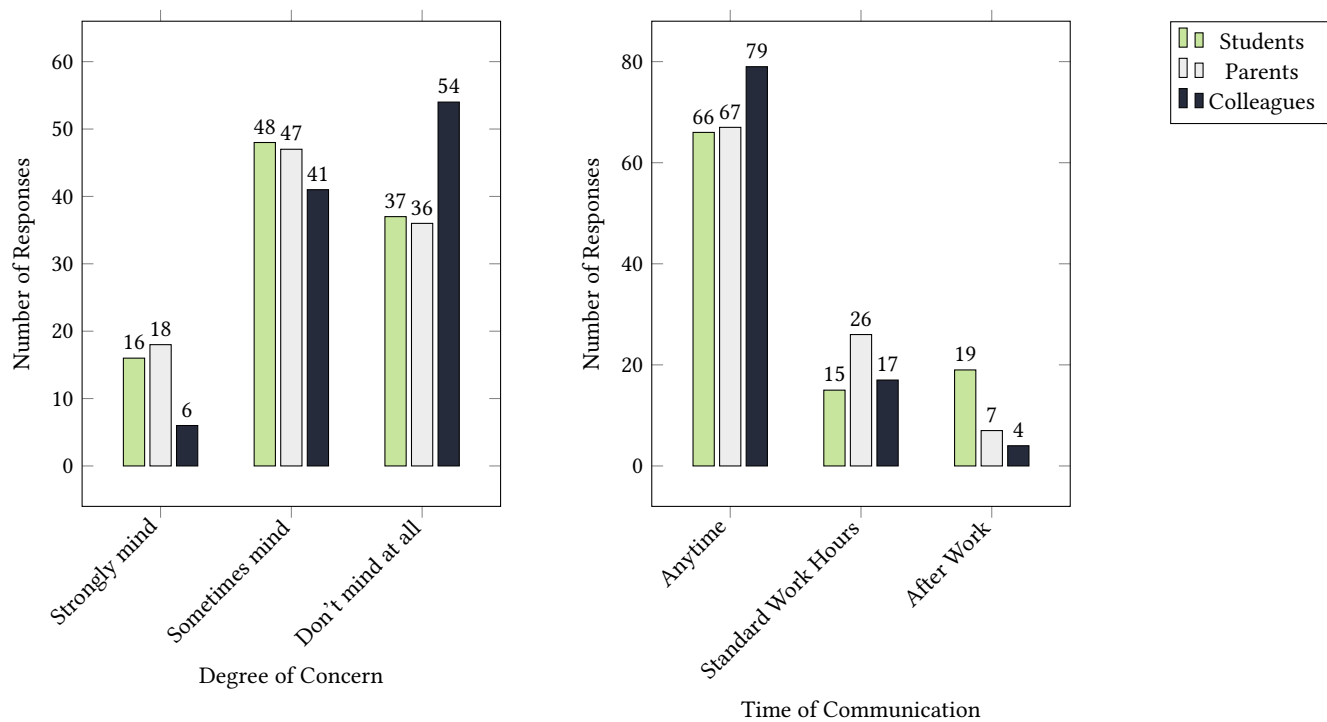


Figure 4: (a) Degree of concern regarding Moments visibility, and (b) timing of WeChat communication with different groups. The shared legend is placed on the right for clarity.

that what they post, especially on Moments, may affect how they are perceived by parents, students, or administrators. As P11 explained,

“I need to consider whether parents will think I’m irresponsible [...] They might question my ability to manage the class or even doubt my competence as a teacher.” (P11)

This fear of reputational risk was common (see **Figure 4(a)**). A repeated-measures ANOVA showed that concern about Moments visibility differs by relationship type ($F(2, 214) = 19.130, p < .001$). Interviews further revealed that teachers fear that sharing personal life on Moments can complicate a carefully cultivated professional image [8, 39, 94]. Many teachers described anxiety that leisure posts might “decrease trust” (P8) or make them appear immature (P6). Even P15, who embraces a fuller self, hesitates to model behaviors she deems inappropriate for students:

“if I post about going to a bar with friends, I don’t want to encourage my students to follow that.” (P15)

WeChat materializes these judgments into public signals, making virtue and reputation visible and evaluable [66, 91]. In the absence of institutional guidelines, teachers navigate these decisions through personal ethics, shaped by a strong awareness of audience expectations, even among those who post more expressively.

4.2.3 Negotiating relational distance within hierarchical and reciprocal obligations. WeChat “friendship” heightens perceived intimacy relative to enterprise tools (e.g., Enterprise WeChat¹⁰ and DingTalk) by exposing Moments “glimpses into personal lives” (P12), humanizing exchanges through emojis and stickers (P11), and fostering “more emotional engagement” (P16). This complicates authority. Prior work has noted professionalism challenges on SNS [8, 39, 94]. P13 described how these affordances blurred her teacher-student boundaries:

“The students often send me funny videos or silly stickers, and it makes me feel that there’s no real sense of distance or formality between us anymore. On WeChat, I’m not just their teacher, I’m part of their friend circle.” (P13)

He further reflected on the tension between approachability and authority:

“If you’re too strict with students, they may become afraid of you. But if you’re too friendly and casual, students might continuously push your boundaries, leading to many classroom management issues.” (P13)

Similarly, P14 observed that parents who use WeChat mainly for personal chat “can easily blur these lines as well” (P14). These tensions unfold within a cultural context shaped by both hierarchy and reciprocity. Teachers are granted institutional authority [51, 105], but are also bound by relational norms of care and mutual obligation [55, 59]. Managing this dual role requires ongoing calibration.

Teachers distinguish between *passive* and *active* engagement [94]. They often treat WeChat as a “window” to better understand students and home contexts (P8 and P5), but recognize that commenting can feel intrusive. P8 recounted that after she privately followed up with a student about a serious post, the student stopped sharing or blocked her. This prompted the teacher to reconsider engaging with students on Moments, recognizing that “students value their personal boundaries and privacy” (P8). Although Moments are technically public, teachers noted they are often intended for closer

ties rather than teachers, which makes teacher engagement feel intrusive to some students:

“Students don’t view teachers as part of their chosen circle of friends, which is why they may feel uncomfortable when we engage with their posts.” (P8)

Because each act of communication carries relational meaning, teachers perform careful emotional labor to maintain both authority and harmony. P5 worried that highlighting one class’s achievements on WeChat Moments could signal favoritism when another class is struggling. P2 described “having to think hard about how to reply”. P8 noted the awkwardness of reacting on Moments while leaving a parent’s message unanswered, and P11 added, “If I ‘like’ one post, does that mean I have to ‘like’ others as well?” These examples show how WeChat amplifies the visibility of small gestures, turning them into moral performances of fairness, respect, and care. By continually calibrating closeness and distance, teachers sustain cooperation and legitimacy within a hierarchy maintained by moral reciprocity. Authority on WeChat is thus relationally enacted. Teachers remain respected not through bureaucratic enforcement but through the moral credibility and social grace demonstrated in everyday digital exchanges.

4.3 RQ3. Developing Workarounds to Maintain Boundary

Boundary work on WeChat operates in three layers that are tightly coupled to the platform’s affordances. Teachers first regulate communication as micro-flows (the selective visibility and salience of information within their chat environment) with WeChat controls, then govern relationships through channel and tempo choices on WeChat, and finally manage visibility and professional identity in WeChat Moments.

4.3.1 Arranging fragmented responsibilities. Rather than running a single coordinated workflow, some teachers use WeChat to granularize communication into small, routable pieces and to regulate pace. They delay non-urgent replies into convenient slots or work hours, which also gives parents time to “figure out less critical issues on their own” (P16). They set channel priorities with *Pin Chats* to “avoid missing anything important” (P6), as P1 noted, “Pinning chats helps distinguish importance. When you open WeChat, you first see those people” (P1). Some order pins by relational closeness (P2). A few treat unread badges as a lightweight “to-do list” (P18).

WeChat’s notification controls further support this micro-fragmentation (see **Figure 5 (b)**). Teachers mute large groups and check them when needed and remain smaller relevant groups active for real-time notifications. Based on the One-Way ANOVA results, different management methods significantly affect users’ work experiences, including perceptions of work-related stress on WeChat ($F = 11.785, p < 0.001$) and satisfaction with WeChat for work ($F = 9.857, p < 0.001$). Our interview findings further reveal that these settings help teachers adjust their notifications to prioritize important messages while minimizing disruptions. For example, WeChat’s *special follow* further allows fine-grained monitoring of key contacts such as administrators (P4). Some teachers created separate WeChat accounts using dual logins to manage work and

¹⁰Enterprise WeChat or WeCom provides the same communication experience as WeChat but is for enterprises that include convenient communication and office automation tools.

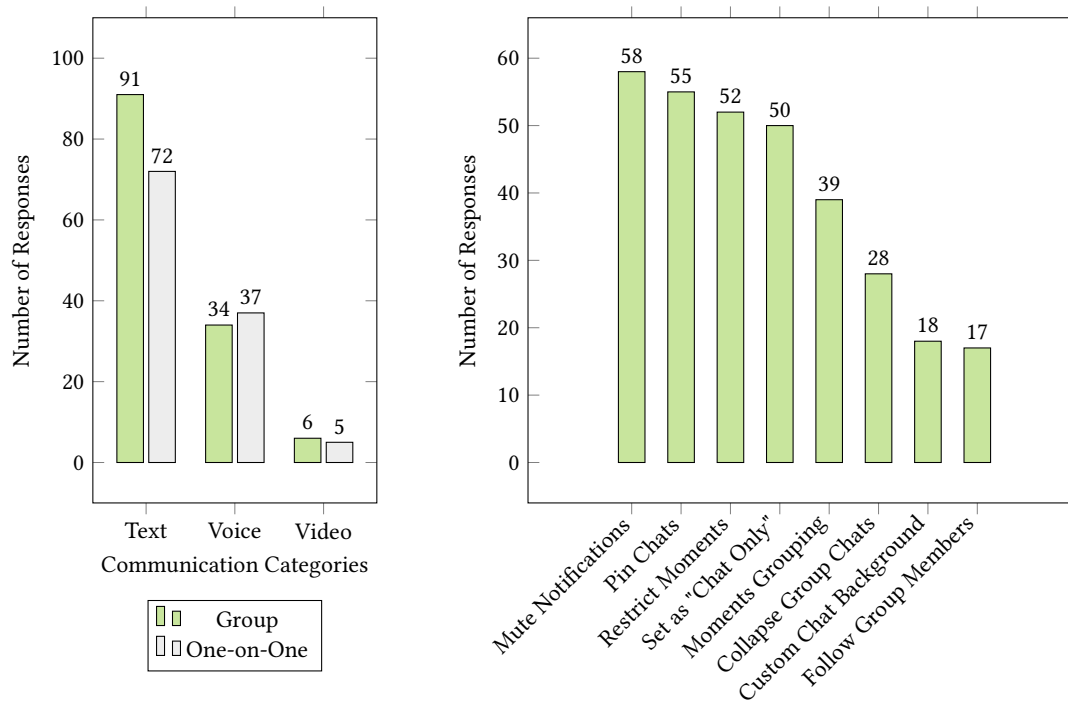


Figure 5: (a) Preferred communication methods on WeChat for group and one-on-one interactions, and (b) methods teachers used for managing WeChat communication and privacy.

personal boundaries (a practice currently only supported on Android devices). A few even purchased a second phone, keeping one for work and the other for personal use. In effect, WeChat's controls act as valves that regulate inflow and outflow, reduce cognitive load, and signal reasonable availability.

4.3.2 Cultivating balanced relationships. Teachers cultivate balanced relationships with students and parents, avoiding being seen as “arrogant or condescending” while fostering “friendly and constructive conversations” (P5). They are more active at transitions, such as “a new quarter starts” (P12), “taking new students” (P16), or “starting at a new school” (P12), to “build trust and establish reputations” (P12). As P12 explained:

“Once the trust is built, [...] parents would generally feel more at ease with the teacher, and they start to understand the hard work involved in teaching, which makes them more respectful of the teacher’s personal time and boundaries.” (P12)

However, maintaining this balance often extends beyond formal duties. Teachers reported frequently managing parents’ emotions, particularly when exam results are released, fearing that “ignoring them could strain the relationships and make future communication more difficult” (P8).

To reclaim professional autonomy, teachers often distance themselves from personal interactions on WeChat. For example, delaying responses. Teachers often reply with, “Sorry, I was busy earlier and didn’t see your message” (P8). P2 said, “After delaying or ignoring the

messages for a few times, parents would know what it means” (P2). By doing so, they create subtle friction that “signals” (P11) boundaries. When asked why teachers choose to deliver such messages in a more implied way, P12 explained,

“It’s because they might feel uncomfortable. Chinese people generally don’t like being too direct. Especially in education, there’s often a sense that it’s somewhat of a service industry.” (P12)

Because Moments is seen as personal space (**Section 4.1.2**), many avoid interacting with work-related individuals’ posts. As P5 explained, “I might see them post on Moments, but I don’t scrutinize it. As a teacher, my responsibility isn’t to overly involve myself in others’ private lives. (P5)” When responding on their own Moments, teachers keep tone light (e.g., an emoji rather than a formal reply) to balance expression with professionalism. Navigating relationships within this perceived personal space adds cognitive load and turns routine exchanges into ongoing boundary work.

4.3.3 Maintaining self-images with minimal efforts. Some teachers maintain a positive public profile while expressing themselves by controlling visibility on Moments (i.e., grouping), separating professional and personal circles. This curation is effortful (**Section 4.2.2**) and can lead to potential issues, such as “accidentally mis-group someone” (P2) can expose private content. To reduce risk, some create separate accounts to compartmentalize information and avoid “sending the wrong message to the wrong person” (P15).

However, despite WeChat's fine privacy controls and the ability to compartmentalize information, to avoid unnecessary complications and mental labor, many teachers opt to withdraw the "self" from WeChat, especially Moments, entirely or just keep the bare minimum. As P2 shared,

"I only post things that are appropriate for everyone to see. It's basically just to show that I'm still around." (P2)

Similarly, P1 noted, *"The more you say, the more mistakes you might make, so I'd rather say nothing at all"* (P1). For these teachers, WeChat has evolved from a social platform to a purely professional tool, with P2 remarking, *"It has lost its function as a platform for sharing or socializing"* (P2). Across these practices, boundary-setting is enacted through relational signaling and collective sense-making. Teachers, parents, and schools read and co-produce cues about availability, privacy, and propriety.

5 Discussion

Through a survey with 108 teachers and in-depth interviews with 18 of them, we found that while WeChat use can intensify boundary strains (e.g., after-hours spillover, heightened expectations of immediacy, and role conflict), it also acts as a constructive *boundary object*, enabling teachers to coordinate fragmented responsibilities that span personal and professional domains (**Section 4.3.1**). Our aim in this discussion is not to portray WeChat as inherently good, nor to dismiss existing work-life boundary theories. Instead, we emphasize that culture should not be treated as monolithic or binary. Building on our findings and prior work on boundary theory, boundary objects, and Chinese cultural logics, we advance four linked arguments: (1) WeChat's infrastructuralization turns it into a constructive boundary object that supports work-life cooperation rather than simply collapsing domains. (2) Expected permeability explains how accessibility becomes a relational and moral expectation, not just an individual preference. (3) Boundary work is distributed across users, relationships, and platform features, not solely located in individual self-control. (4) Taken together, these dynamics invite a shift from individual boundary management to relational boundary negotiation, with implications for the design of all-in-one platforms, that extend beyond what individual-centric accounts predict.

5.1 WeChat as a Boundary Object in Work-Life Cooperation

We first argue that WeChat's infrastructuralization [83, 118] makes it a *boundary object* [5, 64, 93] that organizes cooperation across work and personal domains. In boundary and border theory, mobile technologies often framed as forces that blur or breach the line between "work" and "home", increasing microrole transitions and role conflict [7, 25, 79]. Our findings show a more nuanced configuration. As WeChat becomes infrastructural, it functions as the default layer of coordination across stakeholders (see **Section 4.1.1**). Teachers describe their work as *"continuous"* across the day (see **Section 4.1.3**). This pattern echoes CSCW perspectives that technologies can create, remove, or reconfigure boundaries [15] and that boundary objects are negotiated in situ to enable cooperation among groups with different goals and understandings [70]. Building on Ding et al. [30], WeChat in our setting is not merely

destructive (collapses domains) but constructive (a flexible infrastructure through which boundaries are continually rebuilt) along three dimensions: activities, relationships, and the platform's own adaptability.

First, WeChat constructively reshapes activities by offering a shared space where teachers engage in practices that are neither strictly work-related nor entirely personal. For example, while teachers view parents as work-related contacts, they do not always consider chatting with them as formal work. Teachers also use Moments to share content blending their professional roles and personal interests (**Section 4.2.2**). On the flip side, schools may view WeChat as a platform that crosses the boundary between work and non-work, occasionally requesting teachers to share school-related advertisements in their personal Moments (**Section 4.1.2**). Unlike a purely destructive collapse of work and life, these practices demonstrate how WeChat constructively enables hybrid forms of engagement that sustain, rather than erase, boundary distinctions.

Second, WeChat constructively mediates relationships that are neither strictly formal nor entirely personal. As Ding et al. [30] found with patient-provider communications, WeChat fosters relational modes that balance intimacy with professionalism. Our study similarly found that teachers' relationships with parents and students reflected this balance. Teachers often engage in *passive interaction* [94] with their work-related contacts. For instance, they may view parents' Moments without commenting or liking, using this information as a resource for future engagement. Similarly, when responding to comments from parents on their own non-work-related Moments, teachers make an effort to maintain a personal tone and style, as they regard Moments as a private space, while carefully avoiding expressions that could be interpreted as overly intimate. This nuanced approach shows WeChat's constructive role in sustaining closeness while preserving professional distance.

Finally, WeChat's adaptability constructively supports boundary negotiation. Some teachers use third-party mini-programs (**Section 4.1.1**) to address concerns such as privacy that prior work has raised [39, 49], demonstrating the platform's flexibility.

However, this adaptability is limited by uneven technological proficiency (see **Section 4.3**), institutional support (see **Section 4.2.1**), and access to resources (see **Section 4.3.1**). As a result, teachers face a patchwork of arrangements. These systems work well for those with strong support but remain fragile or nonexistent for others. Privacy protections and workload management often depend on individual improvisation rather than being built into the system. Importantly, even amid such fragility, the presence of these adaptive practices reveals WeChat's constructive potential to generate new ways of managing boundaries.

WeChat's infrastructuralization shapes not only task flow but the conditions that structure boundary work. Continuous visibility, presence cues, and persistent communication channels embed expectations of moralized professional conduct (see **Section 2.2**) into everyday interaction. This always-on visibility aligns with culturally supported notions of duty, rendering accessibility both infrastructurally embedded and socially expected.

5.2 Expected Permeability: Boundary Work as a Relational and Moral Practice

We introduce *expected permeability* as a culturally situated mechanism that explains how boundary *permeability* becomes socially mandated rather than individually chosen. As an extension of Ashforth et al.'s *permeability* dimension, *expected permeability* foregrounds the cultural processes that produce, legitimize, and moralize boundary crossings. Across prior work, boundary theories predominantly conceptualize boundary work as individually constructed, where segmentation protects well-being and flexibility reflects personal agency [7, 25]. Even when Ashforth et al. acknowledge that role transitions are influenced by role senders' expectations, such expectations are treated as contextual pressures on an otherwise individually managed boundary [7]. More recent work challenges this individualistic framing by showing that boundaries are often negotiated within relationships of care, dependency, and trust. For example, in illness recovery, stigma management, and parent-child illness work [3, 92, 113]. We found that teachers' willingness to allow work to cross into personal domains thus does not reflect discretionary flexibility; rather, it reflects hierarchical expectations, reciprocity norms, moral self-discipline, and identity-based notions of what a "good teacher" should be (see **Section 4.2**). In this moral landscape, *permeability* becomes a visible sign of care, diligence, and relational attentiveness. Furthermore, teachers leverage *permeability* as a relational resource. Practices such as scanning parents' and students' Moments, selectively curating one's own visibility, or offering quick emotional reassurance function as relational calibration strategies (see **Section 4.1.2**). These uses of *permeability* show that boundary crossings are not only tolerated, they are actively used to build trust and maintain broader social cohesion. Crucially, WeChat's infrastructural visibility (Moments posts, likes on Short Videos or posts, messages) materializes these cultural expectations and functions as an informal governance mechanism (see **Section 4.2.3**). In the absence of formal boundary policies, infrastructural cues signal when teachers ought to respond, reinforcing the felt need to remain reachable (see **Section 4.2.1**). This is why permeability in this context is not optional or situational, it is expected, continually reinforced by moral logics and platform signals that define what responsible engagement should look like. Together, cultural norms and platform visibility produce what we term *expected permeability*, a socially regulated form of availability that extends beyond individual preference.

5.3 From Individual Boundary Management to Relational Boundary Negotiation

Classic work-life boundary theories (reviewed in **Section 2.1**), largely rooted in Western and individualistic assumptions, prioritize individual autonomy in defining temporal and spatial boundaries [79]. These theories conceptualize *boundary dynamics* as inherently fragile, framing *boundary violations* [61] as central challenges to achieving balance [6, 40, 60], often linked to conflicts of both *identity* and *demand*. Our findings complicate this picture by showing that Chinese teachers rarely treat boundaries as purely individual possessions. Instead, they manage boundaries relationally, optimizing cooperative outcomes rather than merely defending personal space (**Section 4.1.3**).

Specifically, teachers' boundary decisions are appraised in relation to others' availability, emotional states, and perceived welfare. The optimization target thus extends beyond safeguarding one's own time or energy to maintaining the choreography of relational order and cooperative success, ultimately aiming at what can be described as a collective optimum. Boundary "blur" thus functions as a cultural adaptation [24] that serves both individual goals (e.g., professional growth, sense of fulfillment, and personal flexibility) and collective objectives (e.g., the shared success of a class or school).

Concrete practices illustrate this orientation. Teachers intensify communication at key moments (new term, class, or school) to build trust and invest extra emotional labor during high-pressure periods (e.g., grade releases) so that delayed replies are not read as disrespect. These choices function to protect future cooperation (**Section 4.1.3**). These strategies protect long-term cooperation and ensure smoother collaboration across future interactions. Responsiveness is also modulated by relational proximity. For instance, messages from closer ties (e.g., parent committee¹¹) are prioritized over more distant contacts. Unlike universalistic relationship models, Chinese boundary practices emphasize hierarchy, reciprocity, and situational appropriateness [112]. Therefore, These patterns shift the analytic unit from the isolated individual to a web of obligations and expectations. Within this networked logic, timeliness and responsiveness are read less as overreach into private life than as integral components of the professional role.

Building on this, we extend boundary research by framing *relational agency* [34] as a core lens for work-life dynamics. We show how teachers act with and through others by aligning interpretations and coordinating action across multiplex ties (administrators, colleagues, parents, students). In our case, teachers acknowledge the "always-on" pressure of an all-in-one tool but still appropriate platform features to actively restructure access rights and visibility. We argue that designing for negotiated responsiveness, audience-aware visibility, and shared control is relevant not only in Chinese schools but anywhere identities and obligations interlock. Culture sets expectations (*why* permeability is valued). Platform infrastructure provides instruments (*how* permeability is governed). Together they enable relational agency (*what* people do with it), clarifying both promise and strain in WeChat-mediated work-life cooperation and pointing to actionable levers for sustainable practice.

5.4 Design Implications

Informed by Braun and Clarke's approach that variation in lived practice reveals meaningful structure [12, 13] and by Khovanskaya et al.'s account of frictions as generative signals for design [58], we interpret the inconsistencies across teachers' boundary strategies as evidence of underlying social mechanisms. These divergences are not noise or user error. They index how teachers balance moral duty, relational expectations, and infrastructural constraints. We therefore outline design tensions rather than discrete feature requests, because the tensions themselves identify where design must remain flexible, culturally legible, and open to negotiation.

¹¹Parent committee is a group established within schools, called a "Parent Council", where parents can participate in school activities, provide feedback, and essentially act as a representative body for other parents to voice concerns and suggestions to school administration; this is to involve parents in school decision-making processes.

- **Tension 1: Platform universality vs. role-specific obligations** WeChat's infrastructural ubiquity makes it the default channel for school communication (see **Section 4.1.1**). It is not used because it supports boundary management, but because it ensures reach—everyone is available there. In other words, it reduces relational distance. However, once used for work, it brings role-specific expectations that require subtle boundary work. Teachers' needs are niche and relationally complex, shaped by shifting obligations to parents, colleagues, and administrators.

Design opportunity. Algorithms can help. Support relational clusters—features that adapt to group-level norms rather than relying on individual toggles. For example, the “Visible To” setting of WeChat Moments post could be enhanced to automatically suggest contact groupings, easing the burden of manual sorting (see **Section 4.2.2**).

- **Tension 2: Explicit boundary-setting vs. tacit negotiation**

Some teachers manage their availability through implicit cues like timing, tone, and silence (see **Section 4.3.2**). But explicit controls, such as muting or auto-replies, can signal detachment or disrespect in a cultural context where boundaries are relationally felt, not formally declared.

Design opportunity. Avoid features that feel like withdrawal. Instead of highlighting “Do Not Disturb” periods, emphasize active rhythms. For example, a Group Rhythm Awareness feature could allow each user to optionally set their general response windows. Group averages could then inform subtle reminders when sending messages outside of typical active times.

- **Tension 3: Boundary support vs. platform simplicity** WeChat's value lies in its low-friction design. Adding visible or complex boundary tools risks undermining its everyday ease of use and adds to teachers' cognitive load.

Design opportunity. Introduce ambient and optional boundary cues that surface only when relevant. For example, lightweight awareness features could be embedded in the group “Chat Info” panel, alongside “Group Notice”, allowing teachers to share availability context unobtrusively.

- **Tension 4: Productive intimacy vs. emotional overreach** Teachers rely on digital intimacy to build trust (see **Section 4.3.2**) but also face constant emotional demands. Always-on availability becomes a moral expectation, making it difficult to step back without social cost.

Design opportunity. Let the system act as a social buffer. Instead of placing the burden on teachers to signal boundaries, the platform can help externalize and normalize boundary norms. For instance, when a new group is created, the system could prompt all members to co-establish communication expectations, such as preferred active hours. Framing availability as a shared group rhythm, rather than an individual stance, reduces the social cost of deferring or declining engagement.

Overall, We conceptualize WeChat as a boundary object (see **Section 5.1**), a scaffold for boundary communication. Rather than

imposing rigid practices, it should support ongoing, culturally appropriate negotiation. By acting as a social buffer, the system can redistribute the labor and risk of setting boundaries, relieving teachers from the burden of individually managing socially sensitive decisions.

6 Limitations

We acknowledge the limitations of our study. First, while we examined cultural influences on boundary theories, our approach does not attribute these dynamics solely to collectivist culture. Instead, we use culture as an interpretive lens and the Chinese sociocultural environment as a site of observation to explore how boundary negotiation unfolds where relational interdependence is socially emphasized [97, 103, 104]. This perspective enables us to make visible the relational dimensions of boundary work [7] in contexts where collective expectations are pronounced, without claiming that these patterns are unique to China. As an exploratory study, our framing on culturally situated patterns inevitably reductive to the internal diversity within Chinese society. Although our analysis grounded in China, similar findings in Western contexts such as parental communication contribute to teacher burnout [84] suggest broader relevance. However, the lack of cross-cultural comparison limits generalizability. Future work should examine how mobile technologies shape work-life boundaries across diverse cultures. Second, our study primarily used WeChat as a representative *all-in-one* infrastructure to examine teachers' work-life boundaries. While WeChat's *all-in-one* functionality is distinctive, many other applications are increasingly adopting approaches from composite applications [33] and integrated software [65], combining diverse features to create seamless user experiences. This trend opens further opportunities to explore how *all-in-one* platforms impact individuals across diverse cultural and societal backgrounds. Future research would benefit from examining this dimension. Third, our study relied on self-reported methods (i.e., surveys and interviews), rather than objective observations. While these methods are well-suited to capturing participants' subjective perceptions of work-life boundaries, they are prone to biases, such as presenting oneself in a favorable light [82]. Future research could adopt ethnographic or longitudinal approaches to provide a more comprehensive understanding of these dynamics.

7 Conclusion

In this study, we used mixed-methods to examine how Chinese teachers manage work-life boundaries while using WeChat, a multifunctional platform that blends personal and professional domains. Although WeChat intensifies strains such as after-hours spillover and heightened expectations of immediacy, it also operates as constructive work infrastructure that supports coordinating fragmented responsibilities, sustaining relationships, and negotiating access in culturally meaningful ways. Teachers do not treat permeability as an individual preference alone; instead, availability is framed as a moral and relational obligation shaped by hierarchy, reputation, reciprocity, and situational appropriateness. To capture these dynamics, we introduce *expected permeability*, highlighting how boundaries are shaped by internalized social obligations and reinforced by institutional voids. We further reframe boundary

work as *relational boundary negotiation*, distributed across teachers, stakeholders, and platform features. Additionally, we outline four design tensions and corresponding design implications that show how future communication systems might support teachers' boundary work while accommodating role-specific expectations, tacit relational norms, platform simplicity, and the emotional demands of always-on care. Rather than overturning individual-centered models of boundary management, our study shows that individual agency remains important but is only one part of the picture. We foreground a dimension long underemphasized in boundary research: how others' expectations, relational obligations, and platform-mediated visibility actively shape when and how boundaries are negotiated. This perspective extends existing theories by situating boundary practices within their relational and cultural conditions and offers implications for sociotechnical systems that must support negotiated availability, selective visibility, and shared control in contexts where roles and obligations intersect.

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A Survey Questions

Dear Teacher,

Thank you for participating in this study.

Consent Form for Research Participation

Introduction. We sincerely invite primary, middle, and high school teachers who use WeChat for work communication to take part in this research. This study is conducted by a research lab at a university. Our team, led by the principal investigator, consists of interdisciplinary researchers and designers in the field of human-computer interaction, focusing on socio-technical systems and digital mental health.

Before deciding whether to participate, please read this form carefully and feel free to ask any questions. You may contact the research team via [research contact email].

Purpose of the Study. This study explores teachers' mental well-being by examining how educators from primary to high school use instant messaging tools for home-school communication, with the aim of understanding how to better maintain educators' work-life balance.

What You Will Do. The questionnaire will take approximately 10-15 minutes to complete. It includes questions about your use of WeChat for work-related communication. You may skip any question you prefer not to answer. Participation is voluntary, and you may withdraw at any time without penalty.

Risks or Discomforts. The risks involved in this survey are minimal and not greater than those encountered in daily life.

Benefits. While there are no direct personal benefits, your responses will help researchers better understand how information and communication technologies affect teachers' work-life balance.

Voluntary Participation. Your participation is entirely voluntary. You may stop at any time, and your responses will not be recorded.

Rights and Concerns. For more information or questions about the study, please contact the research team via [research contact email]. For concerns about your rights as a research participant, please contact the university's research compliance office at [research compliance contact].

Confidentiality. Your responses will be kept confidential and used only for research purposes. Records will be maintained according to applicable privacy laws. Data will be securely stored on private, institution-maintained servers.

Please ensure you have read the above information carefully. You may print this consent form for your records. Please check the following boxes to confirm that you meet the conditions and voluntarily consent to participate:

- ☐ I am 18 years of age or older.
- ☐ I am currently teaching in a primary, middle, or high school in mainland China.
- ☐ I currently use WeChat for work-related communication.

General Information

- What is your age?
 - 20-25
 - 26-30
 - 31-35
 - 36-40
 - 41-45
 - 46-50
 - 51-55
 - 56-60
 - 61 and above
- What is your gender?
 - Male
 - Female
 - Other (please specify)
- What is your highest education level?
 - Primary school or below
 - Middle school

- High school
- Vocational secondary school
- Associate degree
- Bachelor's degree
- Graduate degree or above
- Other (please specify)

Employment Information

- How many years have you worked in education?
 - Less than 5
 - 5-10
 - 11-15
 - 16-20
 - More than 20
- What level do you currently teach?
 - Primary school
 - Middle school
 - High school
- Where is your school located?
 - Rural (town/village)
 - Urban
- What is your school's boarding model?
 - Day school
 - Semi-boarding (students stay Mon-Fri)
 - Full boarding (students stay the whole term)
- What is your current position? (Select all that apply)
 - Principal
 - Vice Principal
 - Secretary
 - Deputy Secretary
 - Assistant Dean
 - Grade Leader
 - Lesson Planning Group Leader
 - Research Group Leader
 - Homeroom Teacher
 - Assistant Homeroom Teacher
 - Subject Teacher
 - Substitute Teacher
 - Other (please specify)
- Have you ever served as a homeroom teacher?
 - Yes, currently
 - Yes, previously
 - No, never
- Main subject(s) taught
 - (Varies by school level - e.g., Chinese, Math, English, Science, Arts, PE, etc.)

General WeChat Usage and Settings

- Average daily WeChat use:
 - <30 min
 - 30 min-1 hr
 - 1-2 hr
 - 2-3 hr
 - >3 hr
- Do you use multiple WeChat accounts to separate personal and work communication?

- Yes
- No
- Modes of work communication via WeChat (select all that apply):
 - Group text
 - Group voice
 - Group video
 - One-on-one text
 - One-on-one voice
 - One-on-one video
 - Other (specify)

Rate the psychological burden for each communication mode (1 = none, 5 = very high)

	1	2	3	4	5
Group text	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Group voice	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Group video	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
One-on-one text	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
One-on-one voice	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
One-on-one video	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

- Moments content (for work account):
 - Daily life photos
 - Daily reflections
 - School-related photos
 - Work reflections
 - School-assigned promotion
 - Other (specify)
- WeChat management methods (select all that apply):
 - Mute notifications after work
 - Set contacts to “Chat only”
 - Hide or restrict Moments
 - Collapse group chats
 - “Star” key members
 - Pin chats
 - Set special chat backgrounds
 - Use Moments groups
 - Other (specify)

WeChat Communication

Frequency of communication via WeChat	Daily multiple times	Daily once	Few times weekly	Few times monthly	Rarely
Parents	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Students	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Colleagues	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Average daily communication time:	0-0.5 hr	0.5-1 hr	1-2 hr	Over 2 hr
Parents	☐	☐	☐	☐
Students	☐	☐	☐	☐
Colleagues	☐	☐	☐	☐

Expected reply time	Imm	≤1h	½ day	≤1d	≤2d	≤1w	No rep	None	Unsure
Parents	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Students	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Colleagues	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Typical time of communication	Anytime	During work hours	After work
Parents	☐	☐	☐
Students	☐	☐	☐
Colleagues	☐	☐	☐

Do you mind these groups viewing your Moments posts?	Very much	Sometimes	Not at all
Parents	☐	☐	☐
Students	☐	☐	☐
Colleagues	☐	☐	☐

School Support and Training

- Does your school provide guidance or training on using communication software?
 - Yes, detailed guidance
 - Yes, but unclear
 - No
 - Not sure

Personal Digital Boundaries & Well-Being

- How does using WeChat for work affect your stress?
 - Positively supports balance
 - Some positive impact
 - Neutral
 - Some negative impact
 - Strong negative impact
 - Not sure
- Overall satisfaction with WeChat as a work tool:
 - Very satisfied
 - Satisfied
 - Neutral
 - Dissatisfied
 - Very dissatisfied

Follow-up Interview Recruitment

- Dear participant, thank you for your time. Your opinions are very important to our research. Would you like to participate in a follow-up interview?
 - Yes, I am willing to participate (approximately 1 hour). Please leave your WeChat ID/phone number or add our WeChat contact. After completion, you will receive a ¥150 Tmall Supermarket gift card as appreciation.
 - No, I'm unable to participate at this time.

B Interview Questions

Interview Introduction

Thank you very much for your interest in our research project and for taking the time to join this interview. We are looking at WeChat as our main observation site. Because WeChat brings together almost every aspect of daily life and work, we are curious about how teachers, whose jobs require constant interaction with students, parents, and colleagues, balance their personal and professional spaces online and how they understand their use of a personal communication tool for professional purposes.

In this interview, we'll talk about:

- how you currently use WeChat for work communication,
- how you manage interactions with different groups (students, parents, colleagues, and school leaders),
- how these relationships change over time, and
- your personal sense of boundaries between work and private life.

There are no right or wrong answers, we are only interested in your real experiences and thoughts. Before we start, may we record this conversation for transcription purposes?

Interview Questions

- **V1 - Questions Sent to Teachers**
- V1 - Pre-designed follow-up questions
- **V2 - Post-Pilot Test Revision**
- **V3 - "All-in-One" Extension Version**

(1) Please introduce your school and your teaching responsibilities.

- (a) Is your school located in an urban or rural area?
- (b) How is the school positioned in your region's education system?
- (c) How many students are in your class?
- (d) How many classes do you teach?
- (e) What are your main teaching duties?

(2) Could you describe what a typical workday looks like for you?

- (a) What time do you usually start work?
- (b) What is your routine after school ends?

(3) In what situations do you usually use WeChat for work purposes? Can you describe a recent example where you used WeChat to communicate about work?

- (a) Why do you use WeChat rather than other communication methods such as face-to-face conversations, phone calls, or written notes (like parent-teacher notebooks)?
 - (b) In what cases do you take the initiative to contact students, parents, or colleagues on WeChat?
 - (c) In what cases do students, parents, or colleagues usually reach out to you first on WeChat?
- #### (4) After working hours or on weekends, do you still use WeChat often? What do you mainly use it for? Which functions do you use most (for example, short videos, Wallet, official accounts, mini-programs, Channels, or Status)?
- (a) Could you describe how you typically use WeChat in your everyday life?
 - (b) Do you handle work matters through WeChat after hours?
 - (c) If yes, how do you feel about that? Do you see it as overtime? Do you think WeChat intrudes on your personal time?
 - (d) Do your strategies for using WeChat at work differ between working hours and personal time?
 - (e) How does WeChat affect your rest time? Could you describe a recent experience of dealing with work messages during your time off?
 - (f) Overall, how would you describe the role of WeChat in your life?
 - (g) How does the "all-in-one" nature of WeChat (its many functions) influence how you perceive or use this digital space?
- #### (5) What regulations or policies has your school established about teachers using WeChat for work communication?
- (a) How do you view these regulations or policies?
 - (b) Are there areas you think are not yet covered or need improvement?
 - (c) Are there any rules for how parents or students should contact teachers on WeChat?
 - (d) How did you first start using WeChat for school work?
 - (e) Do you use WeChat for work because it's your personal preference, or is it a formal or informal requirement from your school?
 - (f) What do you think is the purpose of these policies—efficiency, maintaining good parent-teacher relationships, protecting students, or something else?
- #### (6) What kind of expectations do students, parents, and colleagues have for how quickly you reply on WeChat?
- (a) How do you manage to meet those expectations while maintaining your own work-life rhythm?
 - (b) When you cannot respond immediately (for example, during class or a meeting), how do you let others know?
 - (c) How do you judge whether a message is urgent and needs an immediate reply?
 - (d) Have you ever received feedback from parents about your communication with them on WeChat?
- #### (7) What do you think are the main advantages and difficulties of using WeChat for work? Please give specific examples, comparing it with the time before WeChat was commonly used.

- (a) Advantages: Do you think WeChat makes communication more efficient and closer? Does it bring teachers, parents, and colleagues nearer to one another? Why? Could you give an example?
- (b) Some teachers say WeCom (Enterprise WeChat) feels lighter—it connects people without creating a “personal relationship.” Why do you think adding someone as a WeChat friend feels like building a relationship?
- (c) Challenges: Why do you sometimes feel irritated when you see work messages after hours? Why is the overlap between life and work disturbing to you? Could you describe how it feels in detail?
- (8) In your daily work, you may need to switch emotions quickly—for example, one moment you’re seriously discussing something with a parent, and the next you’re joking with family or friends. How do you experience this kind of emotional shift?
- (9) **Do you separate your work and personal WeChat accounts?**
 - (a) **If yes:**
 - (i) Could you share how and why you created a separate work account?
 - (ii) What are the differences between your two accounts—in appearance, tone, or use?
 - (iii) Do the two accounts overlap (for example, mutual contacts or shared groups)?
 - (iv) Do you follow any education-related official accounts or Channels on your private account? Why or why not?
 - (b) **If no:**
 - (i) Why did you decide not to separate them?
 - (ii) How do you present yourself on WeChat (name, profile photo, signature, Moments)? Why did you set them that way?
 - (iii) Since you use the same account for both personal and work communication, do you feel less free to express yourself?
 - (iv) How do you maintain a balance between personal and work life within the same digital space?
 - (v) You show both your professional (teacher) and personal sides—what benefits or difficulties come with that?
 - (vi) Do you follow any education-related content on WeChat? Why or why not?
- (10) **Beyond separating accounts, what other strategies do you use to distinguish personal from work space on WeChat? Why do you do this?**
- (11) When you first started teaching or took over a new class, how did you establish communication rules with parents on WeChat? Could you share any experiences?
 - (a) Do you think your method was effective?
 - (b) Why might teachers choose to use excuses instead of clearly expressing their boundaries?
- (12) **What kind of content do you usually share on your WeChat Moments?**
 - (a) Do you have concerns about what you post? What types of posts can parents, students, or colleagues see, and what can’t they see? Why?
 - (b) Do you post reflections or personal feelings?
 - (c) What kind of space do Moments represent for you?
 - (d) Who do you imagine as your main audience when you post?
- (13) Do you share school-related content (daily activities, news, etc.) on your Moments or Channels?
 - (a) Why do you share it—what is your purpose or motivation?
 - (b) What kinds of reactions have you received?
 - (c) What do you consider when posting this type of content?
 - (d) Have you ever encountered problems when sharing work-related posts?
- (14) Has your school ever required teachers to post or repost work-related content on their Moments?
 - (a) If yes, how do you feel about that?
 - (b) Do you post it on your work or personal account?
 - (c) If you don’t repost school materials, do you feel any peer pressure?
- (15) **Have you seen posts from students, parents, colleagues, or school leaders on Moments?**
 - (a) Could you describe what you saw and how you felt about it?
 - (b) How do you feel about their online presence?
- (16) Do you interact (like, comment) with their posts? Why or why not? Could you give a specific example?
- (17) When your relationships change—for instance, when students graduate or colleagues become close friends—how do you handle their WeChat connections?
- (18) Do you consider yourself, your students, and parents to form a “community”? Why? How does this sense of community influence how you interact with them on WeChat?
- (19) To wrap up, what kind of profession do you consider teaching to be? Could you share your thoughts and feelings about being a teacher?
- (20) As you may have noticed, our conversation today has centered on the idea of boundaries. Would you say you have a sense of boundaries? What does “having boundaries” mean to you as a teacher?
- (21) If you were the one setting your school’s WeChat communication rules, how would you design them?
- (22) Finally, is there anything else you’d like to share that we haven’t talked about yet?